



Braille New World

Harry Potter enters the lives of visually challenged students who are busy expanding their universe

■ **By Ambreesh Mishra**

Former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, filmmaker-poet Gulzar and best-selling author J.K. Rowling have little in common—one is India's missile man, another is known for his soulful poetry and the third weaves a world of fantasy. Except that their voluminous books, painstakingly transcribed in Braille, sit astride a long shelf in Arushi's office, an organisation working for the physically challenged in Bhopal. The visually challenged students who have done most of the transcribing take good care of the books so that their labour isn't lost by sloppy handling.

The books are a part of a project initiated by Arushi to bring the joy of reading into the lives of the visually challenged. But the slow transcription process serves a larger purpose. Involving the visually challenged students in the project inculcates an immense sense of self-worth in them. "Even if we have volunteers to help, we keep them away," says Rohit Trivedi, a professor of English literature, who suffers from an impairment of vision himself. When a book needs to be transcribed, a volunteer reads out the text to the student who then types it out on a computer, where a specialised software converts the words into Braille.

It was 10 years ago when Arushi started work in this



direction by first transcribing the textbooks of the Madhya Pradesh Board of Secondary Education and Central Board of Secondary Education into Braille. Anil Mudgal, Arushi's director, felt the need to take the project to the next level so that it would cover a wider gamut of literature. The organisation's collection now stands at over 100 books, including Kalam's *Wings of Fire*, five Harry Potter titles and over 30 titles of Gulzar among others.

But with many publishers coming out with audio CDs of popular books, does the group fear of Braille books being outdated? "The books may be far more expensive than the audio CDs, but Braille is our printed word. You can never put down a good book, can you?" asks Kamal, a Class VIII student.

It hasn't been a smooth process though. More often than not, publishers don't give permission for the transcription of their books due to copyright considerations. "We desperately wanted to transcribe Harivansh Rai Bachchan's *Madhushala* but didn't get the publisher's nod," says Radheshyam, a visually challenged assistant professor associated with the project. Undeterred, the small group is soldiering on. Working with a local bookstore, they have turned it into, perhaps, the first store in the country to stock Braille books. Now, Arushi is working to provide information on historic sites, national parks and museums on Braille. A leadership of vision, indeed. ■